



Spanish women in Madrid, celebrating the victory of Franco's Nationalists in the country's civil war. Defeated opponents of Franco faced harsh oppression.

BY 1939 MILITARY DICTATORSHIPS WERE SPREADING ACROSS EUROPE.

Only a handful of countries, chiefly Britain and France, maintained a liberal democratic system. In the spring, General Francisco Franco's **Nationalists triumphed in the Spanish Civil War**, occupying the surviving Republican strongholds of Barcelona and Madrid. Tens of thousands of Franco's enemies were executed. Others fled into exile, and many were interned in camps in France. Meanwhile, Italy's dictator Benito **Mussolini** (1883–1945) had **annexed Albania**, and driven out its monarch, King Zog (1895–1961).

More threatening for the peace of Europe was German Führer Adolf Hitler's **occupation of Prague**. The Munich agreement

“WHEN STARTING AND WAGING **WAR** IT IS NOT **RIGHT THAT MATTERS, BUT VICTORY.**”

Adolf Hitler, military and political leader of Germany, 30 January 1939

(see 1938) had left Czechoslovakia a defenseless state, and the Germans encouraged Slovakian nationalists, who were resentful of Czech domination, to declare independence. In March, **Hitler's troops marched unopposed into Prague**, turning the Czech lands of Bohemia and Moravia into a German “protectorate.” After Hungary annexed the east, Czechoslovakia ceased to exist as a country.

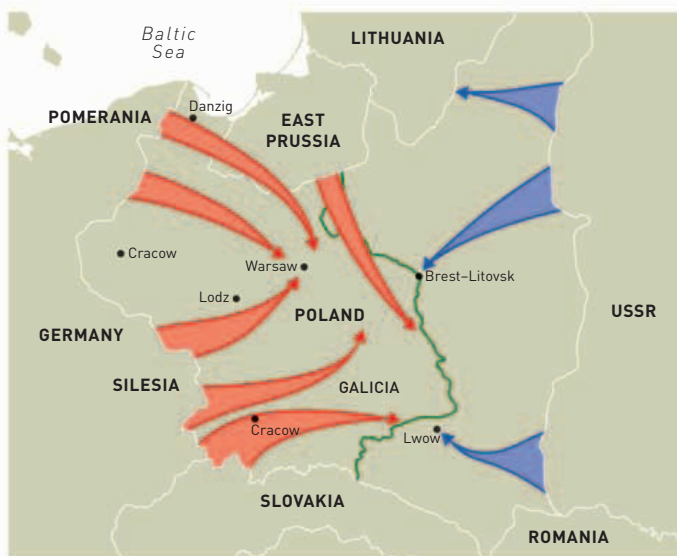
The German occupation of Prague forced the leaders of the Western democracies to acknowledge the ruthlessness of Nazi expansionism. It was obvious **Poland was to be the next target**. Believing a threat of force would deter Hitler, the British and French gave the Poles a guarantee of military support, but Hitler was not deterred. In April he began military planning for an invasion of Poland.

Desperate Jews tried to flee the expanding area coming under Nazi control, but many countries refused to let them in. Among the more fortunate were those rescued by the **Kindertransport** scheme that arranged for almost

Invasion of Poland

German forces invaded Poland from East Prussia, Germany, and Slovakia on September 1. With Nazi agreement, the Soviets occupied eastern Poland.

KEY
 — German advance/operation
 — Soviet advance
 — German/Soviet demarcation line in Poland



EVACUATION OF THE CITIES

At the start of September, Britain and France began to evacuate civilians from danger areas. Expecting air attacks, the British evacuated 1.5 million children from large cities, along with mothers with babies and young children. The French carried out mass evacuations from the border provinces of Alsace and Lorraine in eastern France. Germany did not carry out mass evacuations until heavy bombing began in 1942.



10,000 unaccompanied **Jewish children** to find **refuge** in Britain. Adults were not allowed to accompany them, however, and many of the children never saw their parents again.



While all eyes were focused on Europe, the **Soviet Union was fighting an undeclared war with Japan** in Asia. Throughout the summer, clashes occurred along the border between Mongolia, a Soviet client state, and Japanese-occupied Manchuria. Soviet General Georgy Zhukov's hard-fought victory at the battle of Khalkhin Gol decided the outcome. This defeat influenced the Japanese to pursue naval-led expansion in the Pacific and Southeast Asia, rather than further land conquests in East Asia.

Anticipating a war with Germany, Britain and France unenthusiastically pursued

World War II British gas mask

All British civilians were issued with gas masks, for protection against poison gas air attacks. This brightly-colored mask is for a child.

